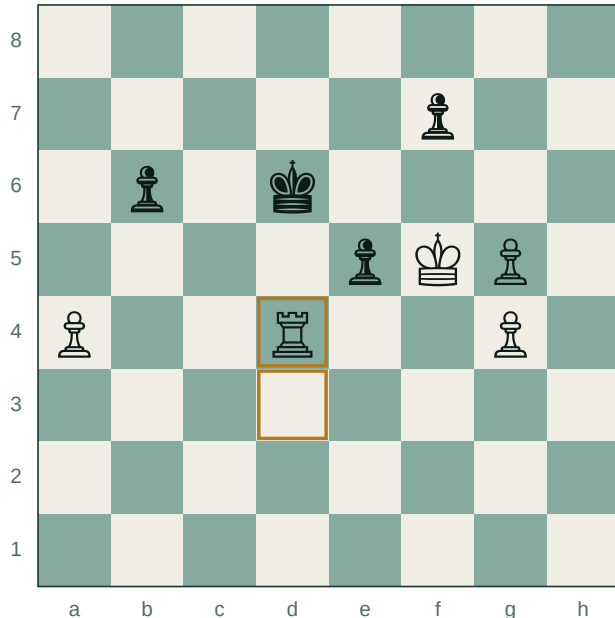


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 49

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 49.Rxd4+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

49...exd4 50. g6 fxg6+ 51. Ke4 Kc5

49...exd4 The pawn captures the rook on d4. Recorded reply: **50.g6**.

50...fxg6+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on g6. Recorded reply: **51.Ke4**.

51...Kc5 The king moves from d6 to c5.

At the end, nominal material is White 2 / Black 3 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -5 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on f5. Geometrically undefended: rook on d4. Check for tactical protection.